Things Fall Apart: Key Quotations

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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When you answer any question on Things Fall Apart, remember that the examiners are looking for you to support your points with references. You can evidence your knowledge of the text in two equally valid ways: both through references **to** it and direct quotations **from** it. Overall, you should aim to secure a strong knowledge of Achebe's novel, as this is how you will be able to select references effectively.

The best way to revise for this question is to group evidence (or key quotes) by character or theme, so you can see the development of Achebe's ideas or his characters. Below you will find definitions and analysis of the best quotations, arranged by the following themes:

- **Culture and identity**
- **Tradition and gender**
- **Fate and free will**
- **Family bonds**

Culture and identity

Chinua Achebe examines the effects of Western culture clashing with **Igbo** culture in a balanced portrayal of Nigerian life at the onset of British **colonialism**. Things Fall Apart portrays the challenges encountered by various members of an **Igbo** village who attempt to maintain their identity amid cultural change.

> **"The band of *egwugwu* moved like a furious whirlwind to Enoch's compound"** – The narrator, Chapter 22

Meaning and context:

- The narrator describes how the masked men who represent **Igbo** spirits take revenge upon a radical Christian convert, Enoch, who has disrespected them
- The narrator explains how unmasking an **egwugwu** is "One of the greatest crimes a man could commit":

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

Analysis

- Achebe portrays violence and confusion as cultures clash in the village when the **missionaries** convert many of the **Igbo** people to Christianity
- The narrator describes the masked **Igbo** spirits in a simile that compares them to a "whirlwind", suggesting their power as well as their fury:
  - This, coupled with the word "band", portrays the spiritual men as one powerful and united force

Paired quotation

> **"The elders consulted their Oracle and it told them that the strange man would break their clan and spread destruction among them"** – Obierika, Chapter 15
>
> **"He has put a knife on the things that held us together and we have fallen apart"** – Obierika, Chapter 21

Meaning and context

Help me understand

- When Obierika relates the **massacre** in Abame, he explains that an **Oracle** warned of destruction as "other white men were on their way"
- Later, Obierika tells Okonkwo that the British men who now govern Umuofia have divided the **Igbo** people, and that their culture is crumbling

Analysis

- Achebe uses metaphorical language that connotes to violent separation to present the destruction of the **Igbo** culture
- The Oracle warns that the British would "break" their clan:
  - The verb signifies a shattering or fragmenting of culture and identity
- Later, Obierika repeats this symbolic message as he describes a violent division by force, a "knife" that breaks them "apart", linking to the novel's title

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Examiners are not assessing your memory of direct quotes. They reward evidence that supports your arguments. This means summarising, paraphrasing, referencing of single words, as well as supporting plot events, will all be considered valid evidence in your interpretations of Things Fall Apart.

Chinua Achebe illustrates the danger of intolerant attitudes and discriminatory customs that oppress people. His tragic novel, Things Fall Apart, illustrates how a tyrannical leadership and traditional ideas of what success looks like can cause divisions in a family and a community.

> **"He was a wealthy farmer and had two barns full of yams, and had just married his third wife"** – The narrator, Chapter 1

Meaning and context

- The narrator immediately portrays the **protagonist**, Okonkwo, in terms of his position as a popular and respected man in the **Igbo** village
- As a wealthy farmer with a large family, he is seen as an accomplished man

Analysis

- The introduction of Okonkwo presents the **Igbo** version of success at the time
- The triple, listing his achievements, highlights the **Igbo** culture as a rural farming community with **patriarchal** values

Paired quotation

> **"Nwoye knew that it was right to be masculine and to be violent, but somehow he still preferred the stories that his mother used to tell"** – The narrator, Chapter 7
>
> **"This was a womanly clan, he thought"** – The narrator, Chapter 18

Meaning and context

- Nwoye, Okonkwo's son, is not the same as his father, and this creates barriers between them, especially as Nwoye wants to please him
- But Nwoye does not like Okonkwo's stories of "violence and bloodshed"
- Okonkwo's attitude to masculinity — he thinks the village's responses to the British is too passive ("womanly") — loses him his son and his clan's respect

Analysis

- Achebe illustrates divisions created by intolerant attitudes:
  - By equating masculinity to violence, Okonkwo alienates his son

presented as the fatal flaw that leads to his downfall

Fate and free will

Chinua Achebe's tragedy considers the universal struggle of exerting one's **autonomy** against external pressures. The novel illustrates how its **protagonist**, unable to alter his path, and under pressure from violent change, is inevitably doomed.

> **"He had a bad chi or personal god, and evil fortune followed him to the grave, or rather to his death, for he had no grave"** – The narrator, Chapter 3

Meaning and context

- Okonkwo's father, Unoka, is described as a cursed man because he is "followed" by bad luck ("evil fortune")
- The narrator introduces the **Igbo chi**, one's personal destiny, which can be overcome by saying yes: taking personal action
- The **Igbo** custom not to bury outcasts is described here: Unoka had "no grave"

Analysis

- Achebe foreshadows the similar fate that Okonkwo ironically shares with his father, a man who he spends his life criticising for his poor character
- The adjective "evil", describing bad luck, speaks to the **Igbo** belief that an individual can resist bad **chi** by behaving well, which equates to free will:
  - This portrays Unoka as accountable for his own failures

Paired quotation

> **"And not only his chi but his clan too, because it judged a man by the work of his hands"** – The narrator, Chapter 4
>
> **"He had been cast out of his clan like a fish onto a dry, sandy beach, panting, clearly his personal god or chi was not made for great things"** – The narrator, Chapter 14

Meaning and context

- The narrator introduces Okonkwo as a well-respected member of the village because he says "yes" to his personal birth god (**chi**) and to his clan:

- When Okonkwo is exiled, he becomes despondent, and begins to think that it is not his destiny to be great

Analysis

- Achebe's tragedy follows a well-respected man who is in harmony with his destiny because his actions are good
- His downfall comes when he submits to his weaknesses and blames his problems on fate or **Igbo chi**:
  - His description of being "cast out" of his home implies self-pity and lack of personal accountability
  - He describes himself as "like a fish" to illustrate his lack of belonging in Mbanta, and the sense that he is struggling to survive

Family bonds

While Things Fall Apart highlights the significance of heritage and family, Achebe also explores the traditions and customs that alienate and cause division in family units.

Paired quotation

> **"It was the fear of himself, lest he should be found to resemble his father"** – The narrator, Chapter 2
>
> **"I will not have a son who cannot hold up his head in the gathering of the clan. I would sooner strangle him with my own hands"** – Okonkwo, Chapter 4

Meaning and context

- The narrator tells readers that Okonkwo's fatal flaw is his "fear" of becoming like his father
- Okonkwo explains his attitude to Ikemefuna (whom he refers to as a son here):
  - He would prefer to have no son than one who does not meet his expectations

Analysis

- Achebe reveals, ironically, that while Okonkwo believes he is the perfect example of a courageous man, he is, in fact, living in fear
- Okonkwo's intolerant position towards the boys in his care **foreshadows** the violence that leads to his murder of Ikemefuna and the loss of his own son

>

Meaning and context

- Okonkwo speaks with the village men about the British men, showing his surprise at the Western family values
- This illustrates the **Igbo patriarchal** system, and how much Okonkwo values it

Analysis

- Achebe highlights how the clash of cultures when the colonists come to the villages extends to family values as well as religious values
- Achebe uses colloquial language as Okonkwo expresses his surprise about some British "tribes" which highlights the alternative, indigenous perspective

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